

POSITIVE SELF-TALK

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Increase the frequency of positive thinking and talking about self, the world, and the future.
2. Report a positive shift in mood based on the implementation of positive self-talk.
3. Break the cycle of distorted negative cognition and replace it with more a more realistic positive view of life.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Anxiety
- Grief/Loss Unresolved
- Low Self-Esteem
- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Explain to the client that our thoughts greatly influence our mood. He/she will tend to think that his/her mood dictates his/her thoughts rather than the reverse that we know is true. Help the client find positive statements to apply to his/her life if the client is unsuccessful at writing them himself/herself. Reinforce the client's daily review of the positive statements to counteract the distortions that feed the depression.

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How soon we forget. This statement is especially true for people struggling with depression. They forget how to think positively and they forget about their worth as individuals, their contribution to society in general, and friends and family in particular. The cloud of depression blocks out the positive and distorts their vision into seeing themselves, the world, and their future as negative. This assignment is designed to help you break out of that self-defeating, unrealistic negative thinking cycle. It will take effort and focused attention to break the bad habit of distorted thinking.

1. List five positive mood-enhancing statements regarding yourself (e.g., “I am a competent person who has had successes”), the world (e.g., “Other people are basically kind and want to be helpful”), and the future (e.g., “As I increase my activity, the future looks brighter”). You must force yourself to focus in on your successes, positive traits, the goodness of people, and an optimistic view of the future. Your tendency will be to think of failures and discount or ignore successes as well as seeing the future as hopeless. In other words, you must think contrary to your natural depressive inclination and return to the realistic positive way of thinking that characterized you before bad habits got a stranglehold on your thoughts.

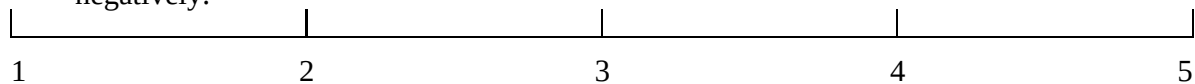
Positive View of Me

Positive View of the World

Positive View of the Future

2. Each day select one mood-enhancing thought from your lists and write it on a piece of paper to be posted somewhere in your house so that it will be easily visible (e.g., on the refrigerator, on a mirror).
3. Stand in front of a mirror each day for 3 minutes and look yourself in the eye while repeating the positive self-talk that you have written in item 1.
4. Explain the impact that the positive self-talk has had on your mood.

5. Rate the degree of improvement in your mood when you think positively versus when you think negatively.



No
Impact

Great
Impact